SpeedUP

English Course

The Language of Discourse

Key Distinction

Cohesion

the surface-level links between sentences (pronouns, connectors, repetition)

Coherence

the logical flow and meaning across the whole text

A text can be cohesive but **not** coherent — and coherent but **not** very cohesive!

Cohesion — Coesão
(noun)

Example Sentence
The essay lacks cohesion — the paragraphs do not connect smoothly.

Cohesion — Coesão
Part of Speech

Example Sentence
A text can be grammatically correct but still lack coherence of ideas.

Coherence — Coerência
Part of Speech

Example Sentence
A text can be grammatically correct but still lack coherence of ideas.

Transition — Transição, Conectar
(noun/verb)

Example Sentence
Words like *however* and *therefore* serve as transitions between ideas.

Paraphrase — Parafrasear
(verb/noun)

Example Sentence
Can you paraphrase that last point? Some students didn't follow it.

Rephrase — Reformular
(verb)

Example Sentence
Let me rephrase that — I don't think I expressed my point clearly.

Word Family Notes

Elaborate →
Elaboration (noun)
→ **Elaborately** (adv.)

Digress →
Digression (noun)

Resume →
Resumption (noun)
⚠️ Do not confuse with "résumé" (CV)

Acknowledge →
Acknowledgement (noun)
(formal)

Word	Translation	Translation	Example Sentence
Elaborate	Elaborar / Desenvolver	Elaborar / Desenvolver	Could you elaborate on how you reached that conclusion?
Digress	Desviar do assunto	Retomar / Continuar	After the interruption, she resumed her argument confidently.
Acknowledge	I realise I'm digressing — let me return to aben to the main point.	Reconhecer / Admitir	Good academic writers acknowledge opposing viewpoints before refuting them.

Beyond "However" and "Therefore"

Advanced Connectors

Move beyond basic connectors to express precise logical relationships and signal a higher register (B2+).

Notwithstanding

Formal / Legal

A pesar disso / Não obstante

The risks were significant; notwithstanding, the board approved the plan.

Albeit

Formal / Literary

Embora / Ainda que

She accepted the offer, albeit reluctantly.

Inasmuch as

Formal / Academic

Na medida em que / Visto que

His findings are relevant inasmuch as they challenge the existing model.

In that

Formal / Academic

No sentido de que / Pois

The policy failed in that it never addressed the root cause.

To the extent that

Formal / Academic

A tal ponto que / Na medida em que

The problem has worsened to the extent that intervention is now unavoidable.

Comparing Advanced vs. Basic

Comparing Advanced vs. Basic Connectors (same meaning):

Basic Connectors	Advanced Connectors	Shift in Register
Although she was tired, she continued.	She continued, albeit exhausted.	Formal, more compact
Because it covers all costs, it's fair.	It is fair inasmuch as it covers all costs.	Academic, more precise
Despite the risks, they proceeded.	Notwithstanding the risks, they proceeded.	Formal / Legal
It was so bad that we had to leave.	It worsened to the extent that we had to leave.	Nuanced degree

Avoiding Unnecessary Repetition

What is Ellipsis?

Ellipsis = omitting words that are already understood from context.

What is Substitution?

Substitution = replacing repeated words with a shorter form (do, so, one, ones, not).

Both are essential for natural, fluent English — and for cohesion without repetition.

Fluent vs. Awkward English

With Repetition (Awkward):

- She wanted to **leave early**. He wanted to **leave early too**. They had decided to **leave early** the day before.
- I like action movies. My sister likes **action movies as well**. We both enjoy watching **action movies** on weekends.

With Ellipsis & Substitution (Fluent):

- She wanted to leave early, and he did too [= wanted to leave early]. They had decided to [= to leave early] the day before.
- I like action movies, and my sister **does too** [= likes them]. We both enjoy watching them on weekends.

Ellipsis & Substitution create smoother, more natural, and efficient communication.

Pointing Back and Forward in a Text

What are Reference Devices?

Words that refer to something already mentioned (**anaphoric**) or soon to be mentioned (**cataphoric**), creating cohesion without repetition.

Anaphoric (Pointing Back)

This (Close / Abstract Idea)

Refers to idea just stated.

Example: Many employees now work remotely. This has changed how teams communicate.

That (Distant Idea)

Refers to a more distant idea.

Example: The old system was inefficient. That became obvious during the audit.

Cataphoric & Others

Such (Previously Described Quality/Type)

Refers to a previously described quality/type.

Example: The board rejected all informal proposals. Such decisions require formal submission.

The former / The latter (First / Second of Two)

Refers to the FIRST (former) or SECOND (latter) of two things mentioned.

Example: We considered both expansion and consolidation. The former was deemed too risky. / Employees preferred flexibility over higher salaries. The latter was less of a priority.

Calibrating the Strength of Your Claims

Why does this matter? In academic, professional, and advanced spoken English, **speakers rarely make absolute claims.** Instead, they hedge (soften, qualify) or boost (strengthen, affirm) their statements to signal certainty level, intellectual honesty, and rhetorical purpose.

Use when: you are not 100% certain, presenting data, or avoiding overgeneralization.

More Tentative / Softened

appears / seems to

The economy appears to be stabilising, according to recent indicators.

there is a possibility that

There is a possibility that the results were influenced by external factors.

Balanced / Qualified

tends to

Example: Remote work tends to improve individual productivity, though results vary.

to some extent

Example: The policy has, to some extent, achieved its intended outcomes.

Evidence-Based / Interpreted

would seem to suggest

Example: The data would seem to suggest a correlation, albeit not a causal link.

it could be argued that

Example: It could be argued that social media has widened, not narrowed, social divides.

More Confident / Generalised

in many / most cases

Example: In most cases, early intervention leads to better long-term results.

CERTAINTY & NUANCE SCALE

Boosting Expressions — Strengthening a Claim

Use when: evidence is strong, making an emphatic point, or expressing consensus.

undoubtedly

This is undoubtedly the most significant reform in a decade.

clearly / evidently

Clearly, the current approach is no longer sustainable.

arguably

This is arguably the most misunderstood concept in modern economics.

it is widely accepted that

It is widely accepted that diversity improves team performance.

there is no question that

There is no question that the decision had lasting consequences.

without doubt

The initiative was, without doubt, a turning point for the organisation.